

OSTRICH RELATIVES



Rheas

Found on the South American pampas, rheas resemble ostriches, but are smaller, with three-toed feet. Both sexes have brown plumage.



Tinamous

These are chicken-sized birds from tropical American grassland and forest. They are the only close ostrich relatives that can take to the air, but they are weak fliers.



Cassowaries

The largest flightless birds from dense rainforest are found in tropical New Guinea and northeastern Australia. They have blue skin on the head and neck.



Emu

Most closely related to the cassowaries, the emu lives on open grassland and deserts of Australia. Like the ostrich, it is adapted to dry conditions.



Kiwis

From the forests of New Zealand, the five species of kiwi are the smallest ostrich relatives and have long bills to probe the ground for prey.

Out in the open

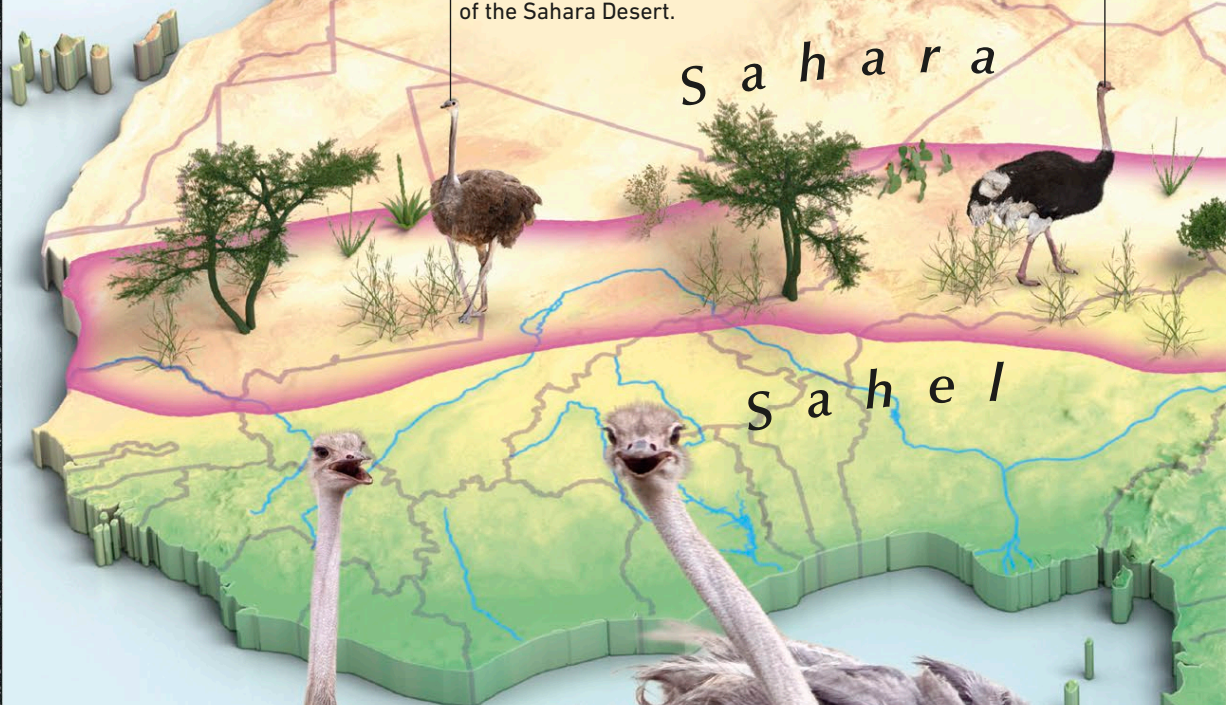
Ostriches are at home on open countryside from desert to savanna, where they live in groups and wander long distances in search of food and water. Food is scarce, so ostriches will eat whatever they can find—roots, seeds, insects, and even small reptiles and mammals.

Male ostrich

Male common ostriches have back plumage with white wings and tail and skin. The females are brownish all over.

Common ostrich

In northern Africa the common ostrich lives mainly in the dry grassland Sahel region, but may wander right to the edge of the Sahara Desert.



Common ostrich

Built to run

The long-legged ostrich is the only bird with just two toes. This reduces the area of each foot in contact with the ground, increasing speed.

KEY

- Common ostrich
- Somali ostrich

ANIMALS IN DANGER

Somali ostrich

- IUCN status: vulnerable
- Population estimate: unknown